



A DATA STORY

What Does *Data* Actually Say About the *Gita*?

*Six widely believed things about the Bhagavad Gita, tested against 700 verses across 9
different analytical methods.*



swipe to see the analysis →

“The Gita is a book of unwavering positivity.”

This is the dominant popular framing: the Gita as a self-help text for optimism and inner peace.

SOURCE / VERIFIED LIVE LINK

“...the Bhagavad Gita is a rich tapestry of insights from the Mahabharata that promote positive thinking and an optimistic outlook.”

yogajala.com/positive-thinking-bhagavad-gita-quotes →

Articles like this dominate the top search results for "Bhagavad Gita meaning." This is what most people believe before reading a single chapter.

↓ WHAT DOES THE DATA SAY?

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

We ran all 700 verses through a 28-emotion classifier (GoEmotions).

TOP 10 TOTAL EMOTION SCORES / REAL VALUES FROM YOUR NOTEBOOK



CONCLUSION

Partially true.

- Neutral dominates at 392 mentions, over 4x the next closest emotion (approval, 96).
- This reads as a mostly instructional, neutral text, not an emotional one.
- Positivity is real here, but it's a minority signal, not the dominant tone.

“Krishna's core message is a call to arms.”

The famous framing: Arjuna refuses to fight, and Krishna spends 18 chapters persuading him back onto the battlefield.

SOURCE / VERIFIED LIVE LINK

“...though the text is absolutely a call to war, it follows this call to war by prescribing a particular disposition and conduct...”

blogs.icrc.org/bhagavad-gita-ethics-war →

Countless summaries reduce the Gita to “Krishna convinces Arjuna to fight,” a war speech dressed in philosophy.

↓ WHAT DOES THE DATA SAY?

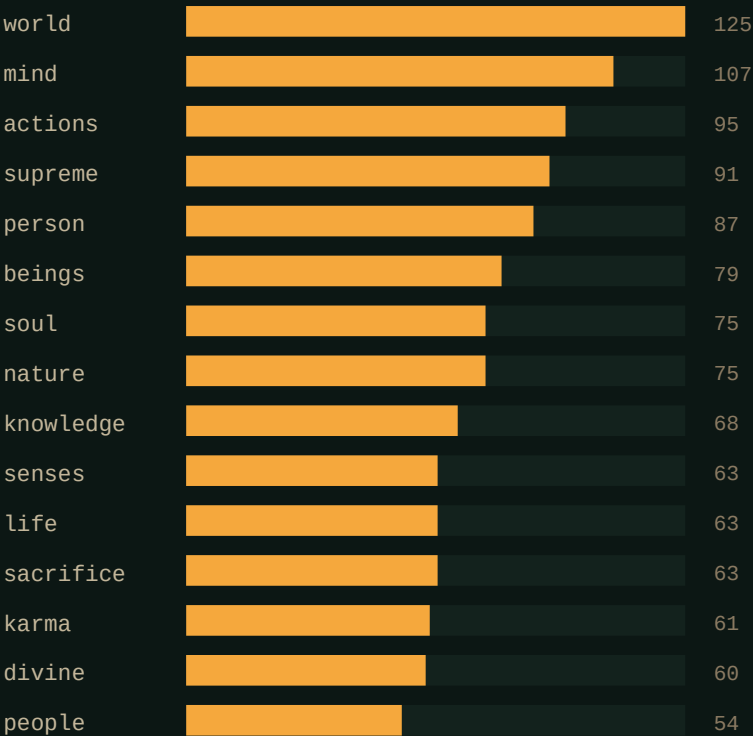
First measurement: if this is a war rally, look at the words actually used.

VERSE SHARE

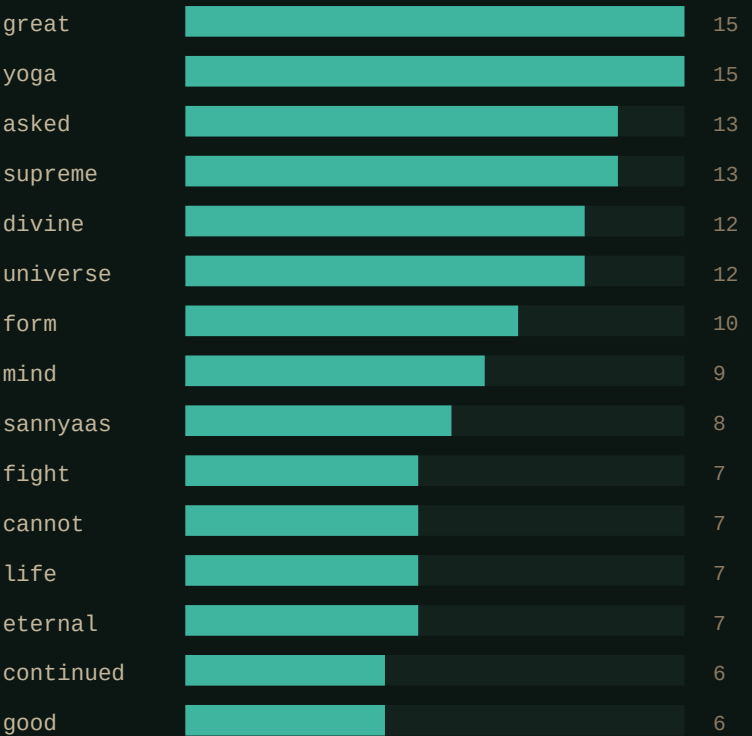


VOCABULARY / REAL VALUES FROM YOUR NOTEBOOK

KRISHNA



ARJUNA



CONCLUSION

False, by vocabulary.

- Krishna carries 80.6% of the text, so his words are effectively its dominant voice.
- Not one war word cracks his top 15: no fight, no battle, no enemy.
- World, mind, actions, soul, nature, knowledge: metaphysics, not a battle cry.

“Chapter 11 is Krishna's scariest, most commanding moment.”

This is the "Now I am become Death" chapter, Krishna's terrifying cosmic form, the single most famous passage in the whole text.

SOURCE / VERIFIED LIVE LINK

“This quotation introduced millions in the West to Krishna's most terrifying self-revelation.”

srimadgita.com/blog/verse-1133-time-destroyer →

Oppenheimer quoted this exact chapter after Trinity. If any moment defines Krishna as overwhelming, it's this one.

↓ WHAT DOES THE DATA SAY?

What actually peaks in his most terrifying chapter.

KRISHNA'S EMOTIONAL ARC / REAL VALUES FROM YOUR NOTEBOOK

	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18
approval	.13	.15	.15	.17	.21	.13	.12	.18	.13	.07	.16	.12	.13	.17	.14	.22	.18
admiration	.07	.07	.08	.10	.11	.13	.06	.08	.18	.07	.09	.04	.10	.16	.11	.11	.10
caring	.11	.06	.03	.07	.06	.03	.09	.12	.07	.18	.15	.00	.02	.02	.03	.02	.09
realization	.03	.02	.03	.08	.04	.02	.01	.06	.02	.01	.01	.07	.10	.04	.02	.03	.04
joy	.04	.00	.01	.11	.06	.00	.05	.03	.02	.01	.00	.00	.01	.01	.04	.01	.07
love	.00	.00	.02	.00	.01	.03	.01	.05	.04	.13	.04	.00	.00	.00	.00	.03	.05
optimism	.03	.04	.03	.02	.03	.01	.02	.03	.02	.03	.02	.01	.01	.01	.03	.01	.02
annoyance	.04	.04	.01	.01	.01	.02	.00	.02	.00	.01	.01	.01	.02	.01	.07	.03	.01
disapproval	.04	.02	.02	.01	.01	.02	.00	.02	.00	.01	.02	.01	.01	.01	.05	.04	.02

CONCLUSION

Backwards.

- Caring peaks at Ch11 (0.18) and love peaks at Ch11 (0.13), both their highest points anywhere in his arc.
- The chapter where Krishna is most overwhelming is also the chapter where he's most comforting.
- Approval, not fear, actually saturates his voice, peaking at Ch5 (0.21) and Ch17 (0.22).

“Arjuna is defined by despair and grief.”

Not just popular reading; this is the text's own framing. Chapter 1 carries an actual name in Sanskrit.

SOURCE / VERIFIED LIVE LINK

“Chapter 1: Arjun Vishād Yog” — “Lamenting the Consequences of War.” The chapter's own title, in the original Sanskrit.

holy-bhagavad-gita.org/chapter/1 →

The text itself named him for his grief before a single teaching had even begun.

↓ WHAT DOES THE DATA SAY?

His own named chapter versus his emotional average across all 18.

ARJUNA'S EMOTIONAL ARC / REAL VALUES FROM YOUR NOTEBOOK

	1	2	3	4	5	6	8	10	11	12	14	17	18
curiosity	.07	.15	.27	.03	.04	.20	.34	.08	.02	.37	.08	.55	.08
confusion	.07	.16	.36	.18	.16	.12	.24	.01	.07	.17	.03	.18	.03
admiration	.00	.07	.00	.03	.05	.00	.00	.33	.34	.00	.10	.00	.28
approval	.03	.05	.03	.07	.17	.05	.01	.23	.06	.01	.10	.01	.09
joy	.00	.14	.00	.00	.07	.00	.00	.00	.04	.00	.08	.00	.01
caring	.01	.06	.01	.01	.02	.01	.00	.02	.04	.00	.01	.00	.10
sadness	.13	.11	.00	.00	.00	.01	.00	.00	.04	.00	.00	.00	.00
disapproval	.06	.02	.01	.01	.02	.07	.03	.00	.01	.00	.01	.01	.00
annoyance	.06	.03	.01	.01	.01	.03	.02	.01	.01	.01	.01	.01	.01

CONCLUSION

True for one chapter, false overall.

- Sadness is real at Ch1 (0.13) but collapses to near-zero by Ch3 and never returns.
- Averaged across everything he says: curiosity (≈0.18) beats confusion (≈0.14) beats sadness (≈0.02).
- Despair is his opening scene, not his character.

“The Gita teaches one consistent message throughout.”

Many readers treat the Gita as delivering a single core teaching, repeated in different words across 18 chapters.

SOURCE / VERIFIED LIVE LINK

“...devotional service to Krishna...is the most confidential part of knowledge, and this is the essence of the whole Bhagavad-gita.” (on verse 18.66)

btg.krishna.com/the-essence-of-the-essence →

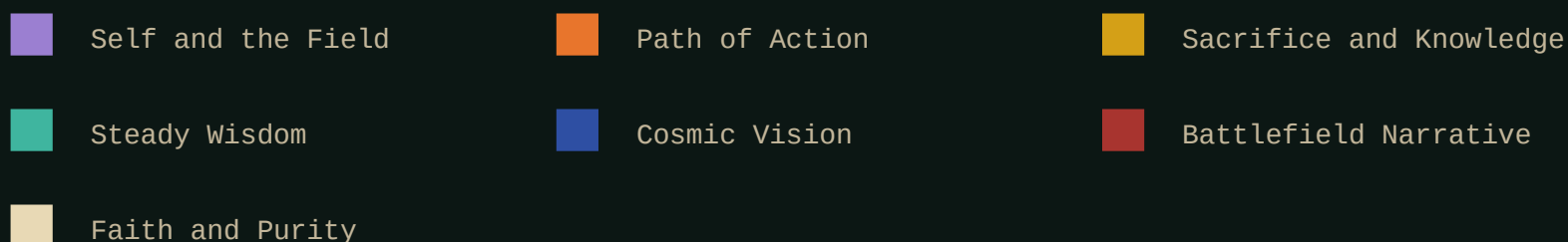
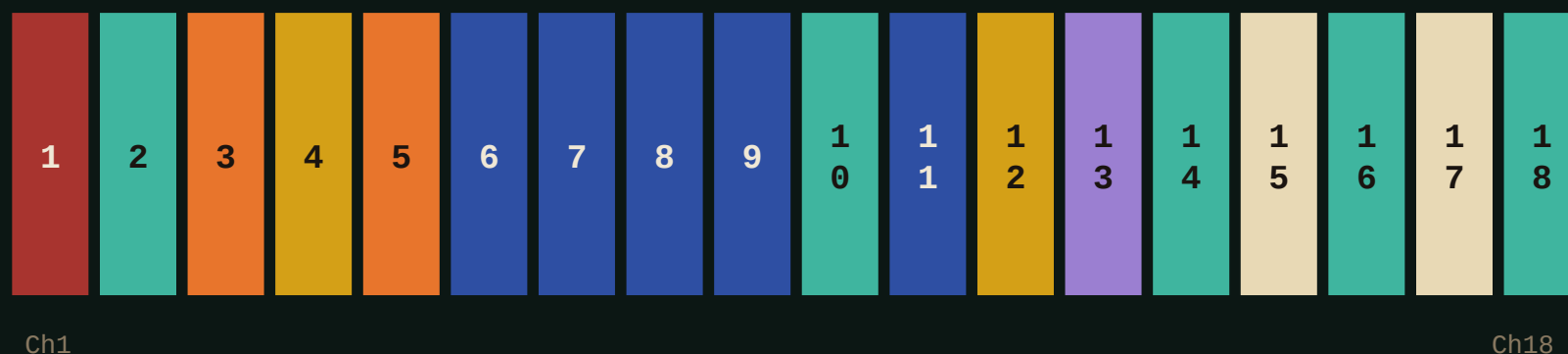
Entire commentaries are built around finding "the one verse" that summarizes the whole text.

↓ WHAT DOES THE DATA SAY?

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

We ran topic modeling (LDA) on all 18 chapters, letting themes emerge on their own, unlabeled.

DOMINANT THEME BY CHAPTER / REAL VALUES FROM YOUR NOTEBOOK



(An 8th theme was discovered but never dominates a single chapter, effectively noise.)

CONCLUSION

False.

- The dominant theme swings hard, chapter to chapter, no straight line toward one lesson.
- Battlefield, wisdom, action, sacrifice, action, a four-chapter cosmic-vision run, sacrifice, self.
- Then wisdom and faith keep trading off all the way to the end.
- It's a text that keeps changing its own subject.

The exact numbers behind the color strip, chapter by chapter.

LDA TOPIC STRENGTH / REAL VALUES FROM YOUR NOTEBOOK

	Self	Action	Sacrifice	Wisdom	Cosmic	Minor	Battle	Faith
Ch1	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	1.00	.00
Ch2	.00	.00	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch3	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch4	.00	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch5	.00	.64	.00	.00	.36	.00	.00	.00
Ch6	.00	.00	.00	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch7	.00	.00	.00	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch8	.00	.00	.00	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch9	.00	.00	.17	.00	.74	.00	.09	.00
Ch10	.00	.00	.00	.98	.02	.00	.00	.00
Ch11	.00	.00	.00	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch12	.00	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch13	1.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch14	.00	.00	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00	.00
Ch15	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	1.00
Ch16	.00	.00	.00	.66	.23	.00	.00	.11
Ch17	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	.00	1.00
Ch18	.00	.00	.00	1.00	.00	.00	.00	.00

CONCLUSION

Notice the extremes, and the empty column.

- Most chapters lock almost entirely onto one theme, not a gentle blend.
- "Minor" (5th column) never wins anywhere: 0.00 in every single row.
- Real noise the model produced, but no chapter ever actually needed it.

“It's easy to understand, for a mature mind.”

A common reassurance to new readers: the philosophy is deep, but the language itself won't be the obstacle.

SOURCE / VERIFIED LIVE LINK

“The Gita is very easy to understand in any language for a mature mind. A repeated reading...will reveal all the sublime ideas contained in it.”

gita-society.com/Read-bhagavad-gita →

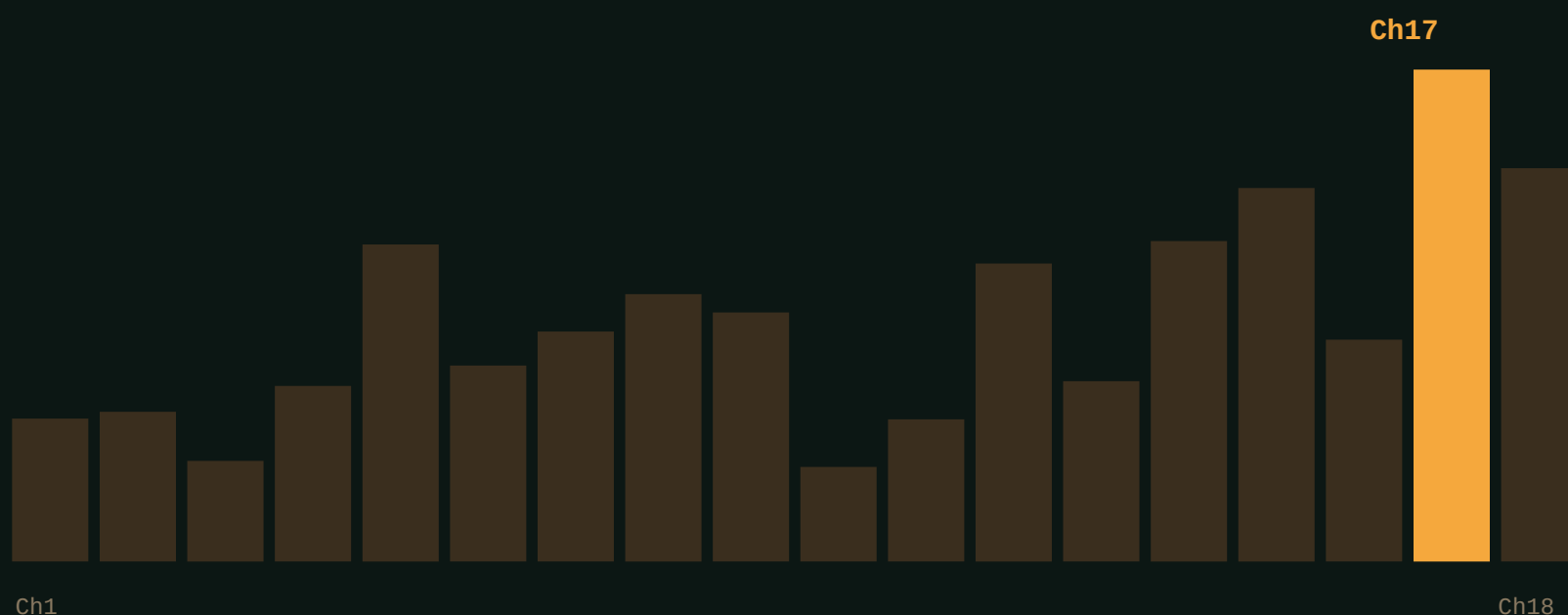
“Mature mind” is doing a lot of quiet work in that sentence. What does the reading level actually require?

↓ WHAT DOES THE DATA SAY?

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

We measured the real Flesch-Kincaid grade level of every chapter.

READING GRADE LEVEL BY CHAPTER / REAL VALUES FROM YOUR NOTEBOOK



CONCLUSION

Half right.

- Average grade level across all 18 chapters is 12.7: college-entry reading, not simple prose.
- It ranges from 10.4 up to 16.2 at Chapter 17, genuine college-level density.
- "Easy" undersells it. "For a mature mind" turns out to be the accurate part.



THE TAKEAWAY

Popular belief gets the Gita half right, at best.

Positive where it feels anything, but mostly silent. No war words in Krishna's own voice. Most comforting exactly where he's most terrifying. Despairing for one chapter, curious for seventeen. A quarter of its themes hold up under scrutiny. Genuinely hard to read, not simply hard to accept. Every claim, tested, not assumed.

BUILT WITH

spaCy dependency parsing · GoEmotions (28-class RoBERTa) · LDA topic modeling · LaBSE cross-lingual embeddings · textstat · pandas · seaborn

700 verses · 18 chapters · 9 analytical methods · zero assumptions on faith



Full interactive breakdown in comments ↓